

The Art of Breaking Things

(Before Your Users Do)

“Tests prove it works; quality proves it works when life goes wrong.”

Goal: Think like a tester – not to find fault, but to find truth



Renee Cocca

Principal Software Test Engineer

Mindex Technologies Inc.

Welcome & Warm-Up

Who writes tests?

Who enjoys breaking their
own code?

Today: We will learn the art of
finding risk before users find
pain.



**Can't find
the bug
all week...**

**User finds
it in 3 seconds.**



Why Passing Tests $\neq$ Quality

- Tests check what we expect.
- Bugs hide where we don't expect.
- Quality = resilience under chaos.

- Developer: How does it work?
- Tester: When does it fail?

Developer vs. Tester Thinking

- Lesson: Quality belongs to the whole team.

The Testing Mindset

- Curiosity - Ask “What if?”
- Skepticism - Challenge assumptions
- Empathy - Think like your users



Mini Lab: The Mystery Requirement

Concept: Hidden assumptions in specs.

Setup: We are given some documentation where emails will be sent to only those relationships selected.

What questions should we ask before we start testing?

Lesson: Quality begins with curiosity before code.

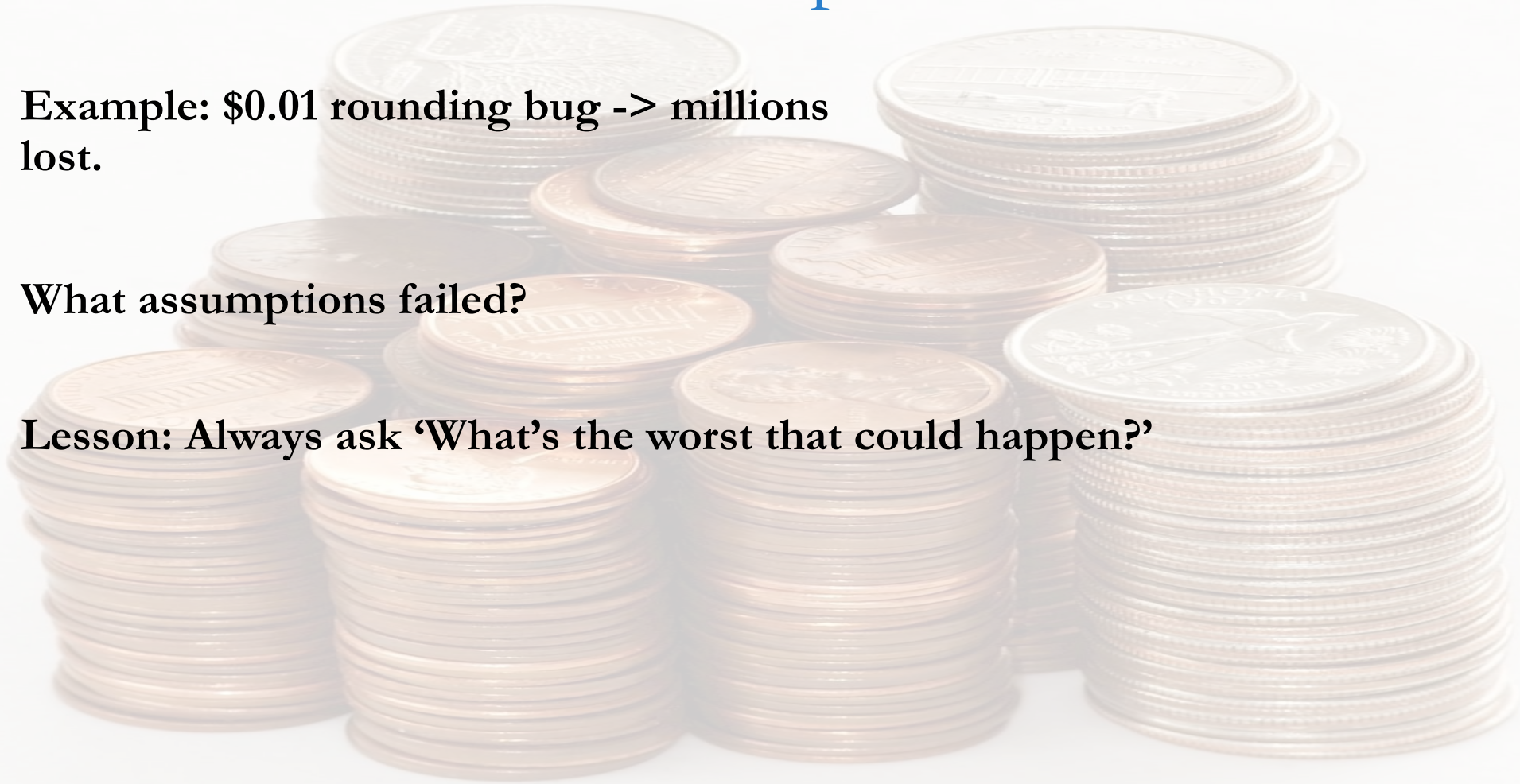


Mini Lab: Real-World Oops

Example: \$0.01 rounding bug -> millions lost.

What assumptions failed?

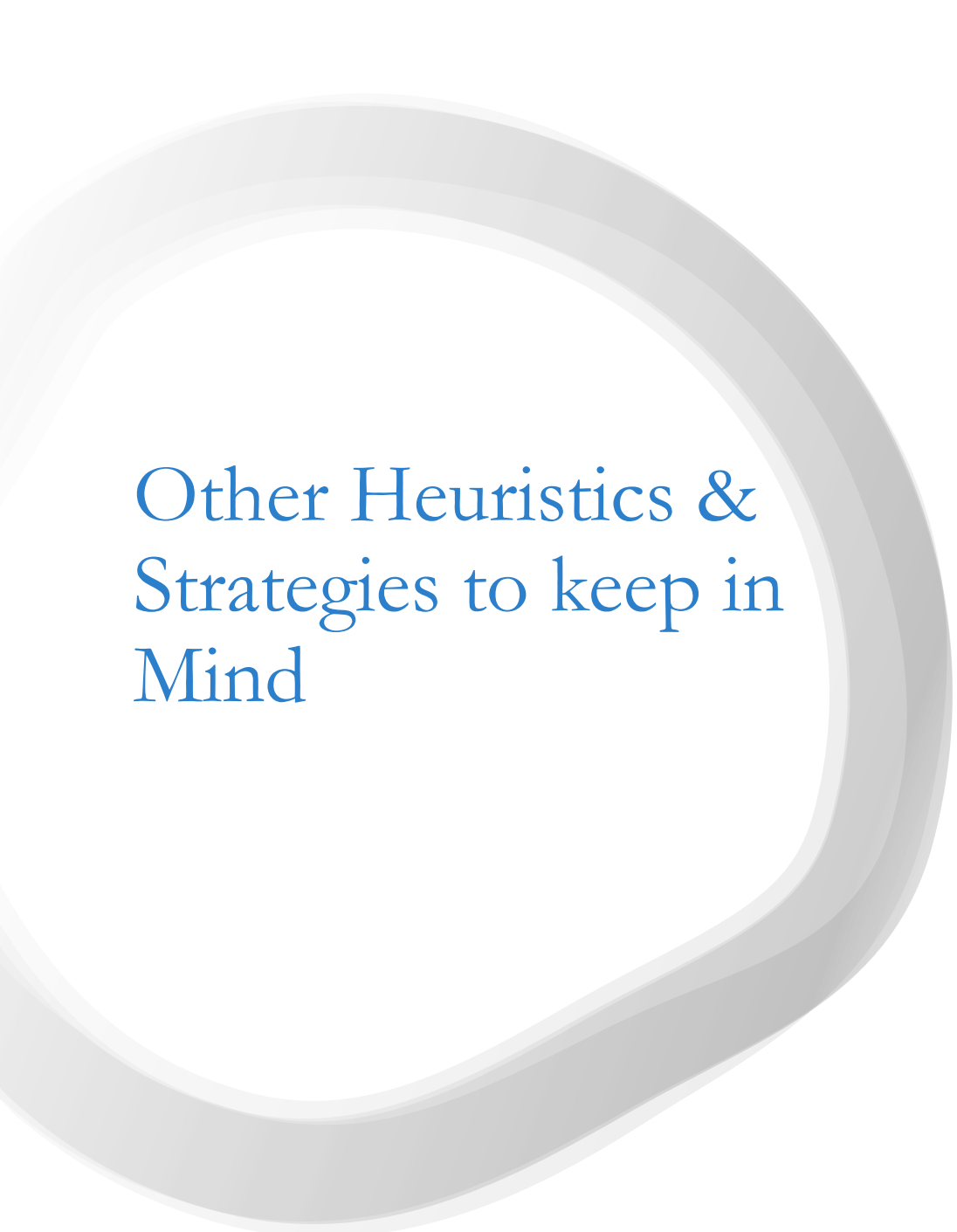
Lesson: Always ask 'What's the worst that could happen?'



Practical Heuristics & Strategies

- Boundaries
- Bad Input
- Behavior

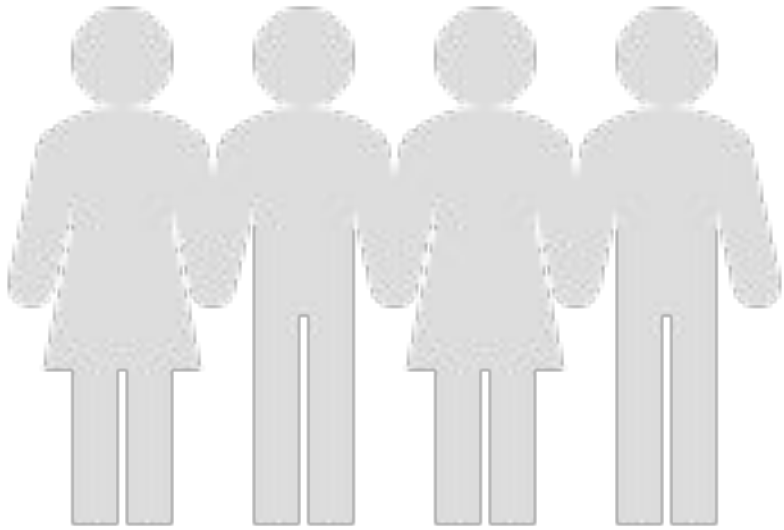




Other Heuristics & Strategies to keep in Mind

- CRUD + EVIL DATA
- CRCRCR
- Risk Storming

Shifting Team Culture



- Quality = Everyone's job
- Ask “What if?” in code reviews.
- Add exploration time in sprints and include everyone in doing the exploring.
- Celebrate preventing bugs.

Wrap-Up & Takeaways

- Tests prove it works.
- Quality proves it works when life goes wrong.
 - Break things before users do.

